

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 3

Chapter 7: The Gupta Era

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	7 — The Gupta Era
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Chandragupta II (Gupta) is a different ruler from Chandragupta Maurya centuries earlier; the Iron Pillar resists rust because of its phosphorus-rich iron forming a protective layer, not because iron 'cannot rust'; Faxian mostly described prosperous cities and must be cross-checked; a 'Golden Age' means cultural brilliance, not equality for everyone. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A student lists the Gupta rulers in the order Samudragupta → Chandragupta I → Chandragupta II. What single correction makes the chronology right?

(A) Chandragupta II must be moved to the very front, before Samudragupta and Chandragupta I.

(B) Chandragupta I must come first, before his son Samudragupta, who is then followed by Chandragupta II.

(C) Samudragupta is correctly first; only Chandragupta I and Chandragupta II need to be swapped.

(D) No correction is needed because all three names refer to the same king at different ages.

2. Why is it a factual error to credit the conquests recorded in the Prayaga (Allahabad) Prashasti to Chandragupta II rather than Samudragupta?

- (A) Both rulers are named in the same prashasti as joint conquerors, so either credit is acceptable.
- (B) The prashasti is a praise-inscription of Samudragupta's military campaigns; Chandragupta II was his successor and is associated with later cultural splendour, not that inscription.
- (C) Chandragupta II composed the prashasti himself, so the conquests it lists are his own.
- (D) The prashasti actually praises Chandragupta Maurya, so neither Gupta ruler should be credited.

3. The 'Chandra' inscription on the Delhi Iron Pillar is generally linked to Chandragupta II. Which reasoning best shows why it cannot belong to Chandragupta Maurya?

- (A) Chandragupta Maurya ruled centuries earlier in the Mauryan age, while the pillar's style and the Gupta-era 'Chandra' fit Chandragupta II of the Gupta dynasty.
- (B) Chandragupta Maurya never used the name element 'Chandra', so no inscription could ever refer to him.
- (C) The Mauryas worked only in gold, so they could not have raised an iron pillar at all.
- (D) Both kings share the title Vikramaditya, so the inscription must mean whichever ruled in Delhi.

4. A guidebook says the Iron Pillar 'has not rusted because iron simply does not rust.' What is wrong with this statement?

- (A) Nothing is wrong; iron is in fact a metal that can never corrode under any conditions.
- (B) Ordinary iron does rust; the pillar resists it because its phosphorus-rich iron forms a thin protective layer that seals out moisture and air.
- (C) It is wrong only because the pillar is actually made of bronze, not iron at all.
- (D) It is wrong because the pillar is repainted with a rust-proof coating every year.

5. Faxian described Gupta cities as prosperous and full of charitable rest-houses, yet a careful historian treats this as only part of the picture chiefly because:

- (A) He wrote the account many centuries after the Gupta age, so none of it is reliable.
- (B) He never actually visited India and copied his report from Roman traders.
- (C) He recorded mainly the well-off urban scenes he saw and also noted that 'untouchable' chandalas were forced to live apart, so his account must be cross-checked.
- (D) He was a Gupta court official paid to praise the empire, so his words are pure flattery.

6. Granting many tax-free agrahara villages to brahmins and temples is best understood as a policy that could, over time, do what to royal power?

- (A) Permanently increase the treasury, since tax-free land paid double the usual taxes.
- (B) Force the king to abolish his army because grant-holders supplied all soldiers.

(C) Slowly shrink the king's tax revenue and pass local authority to grant-holders, weakening direct royal control.

(D) End the empire's overseas trade by tying all merchants to temple land.

7. Compared with the Mauryan ideal of governing every region directly, the Gupta state is best described as relying more on:

(A) Allied and subordinate kings together with land grants, governing the north and centre directly but the rest more loosely.

(B) An elected national assembly that chose the emperor each year.

(C) Foreign Roman administrators sent to run every Gupta province.

(D) Total withdrawal of the king from any role in administration.

8. Chandragupta II is famous for defeating the Shakas (Western Kshatrapas). What practical gain did this victory bring the empire?

(A) The conquest of China, opening the overland route to the Pacific.

(B) The end of the Mauryan dynasty, which the Shakas had been protecting.

(C) The discovery of zero, which the defeated Shakas had been hiding.

(D) Control of the western regions and their ports, extending Gupta reach toward the Arabian Sea and its trade.

9. Aryabhata is credited with arguing that the apparent daily turning of the stars is caused by the Earth's own rotation. Why was this insight remarkable for its time?

(A) It proved that the Earth is flat and rests on a fixed pillar.

(B) It showed the Sun travels around the Earth once each year.

(C) It declared that the stars themselves physically move across India each night.

(D) It explained the everyday sight of the sky wheeling overhead by the Earth spinning, rather than assuming the whole heavens revolve around a still Earth.

10. The Indian concept of shunya (zero) together with the place-value system is judged a world-changing contribution mainly because it:

(A) Allowed Indians to stop using every other number entirely.

(B) Made writing and calculating with very large numbers far simpler, and the system later spread across the world.

(C) Was applied only to measuring temple heights and nowhere else.

(D) Was used once by Aryabhata and then forgotten for centuries.

11. Assertion: The Prayaga Prashasti is valuable evidence for Samudragupta's reign.

Reason: It was composed by his own court poet Harishena. Which is the best judgement?

(A) Both are true, and the courtly authorship guarantees every word is plain, unbiased fact.

(B) The assertion is true and the reason is true, but a historian must read the praise critically because the author served the king.

- (C) The assertion is false because court poetry can never be used as historical evidence.
- (D) The reason is false because Harishena was actually a rival king, not a court poet.

12. Nalanda flourished in this era as a great centre of learning. What does its fame as a destination for scholars from distant lands tell us about Gupta-age India?

- (A) It shows that learning in India was open only to foreign students and barred to locals.
- (B) It proves that the Guptas forbade all study within their own borders.
- (C) It indicates that Nalanda was a military fort rather than a place of study.
- (D) Its intellectual life attracted students from far away, marking it as a hub of advanced learning that drew international attention.

13. Gupta kings issued finely designed gold coins showing themselves performing rituals, playing the lyre, or as archers. The best explanation for this variety of images is that the coins were meant to:

- (A) Serve purely as decorative jewellery with no message at all.
- (B) Advertise the ruler's power, achievements and legitimacy across the realm.
- (C) Record the daily weather for farmers across the empire.
- (D) Prove that the Guptas had no army and ruled only by music.

14. The cave paintings of Ajanta are often cited as a peak of Gupta-age art. Which statement about them is historically accurate?

- (A) They are gold coins minted by Samudragupta to record his victories.
- (B) They are scientific star-charts drawn by Aryabhata for navigation.
- (C) They are royal land-grant deeds inscribed on copper plates.
- (D) They are wall paintings, many on Buddhist themes, showing the refined artistic skill of the period.

15. Why does the title 'Maharajadhiraja' ('great king of kings') used by Gupta rulers tell us something different about their politics than a simple title like 'raja'?

- (A) It signals that the ruler was only a village headman with no kingdom.
- (B) It means the ruler had given up all royal power to a council.
- (C) It shows the ruler served as a priest rather than as a king.
- (D) It claims supremacy over other kings, implying the Gupta ruler stood above lesser kings who acknowledged him.

16. Kalidasa's plays and poems are still studied and performed about 1,500 years later. The best conclusion to draw from this is that:

- (A) The works must really have been written in modern times, not the Gupta age.
- (B) Gupta-age literature produced works of lasting artistic value that outlived the empire itself.
- (C) Gupta culture cared only for science and never for the arts.
- (D) Nothing made during the Gupta period managed to survive at all.

17. Indian merchants' graffiti found in a cave on Socotra, far out in the Indian Ocean, is best read as evidence that:

- (A) The Gupta empire had conquered and ruled the island of Socotra.
- (B) Indian traders of the period sailed and traded over long distances across the Indian Ocean.
- (C) Socotra was actually the Gupta capital instead of Pataliputra.
- (D) Sailors from Socotra had invaded and settled in northern India.

18. Saying the Gupta age was a 'Golden Age' is defensible for its culture but misleading if taken to mean equality, because the period also saw:

- (A) Every subject enjoying identical wealth and rights regardless of birth.
- (B) A complete absence of any warfare or hardship anywhere.
- (C) The harsh exclusion of groups such as the chandalas, who were treated as 'untouchable' and made to live apart.
- (D) The total isolation of India from all outside contact.

19. The Gupta empire's decline in the 6th century CE is most directly linked to:

- (A) A conquest of the north by the Pallavas of Kanchipuram.
- (B) An invasion led by Roman legions from the west.
- (C) Repeated pressure and invasions by the Hunas entering through the northwest.
- (D) The assassination of Chandragupta Maurya, which left no heir.

20. That the Pallavas in the south and Kamarupa in the northeast flourished at the same time as the Guptas leads to which conclusion about Gupta India?

- (A) The Guptas were the only kingdom anywhere in the whole of India.
- (B) India was at that time ruled as a single province of China.
- (C) The Pallavas and Kamarupa were merely Gupta villages with no rulers.
- (D) The Guptas were a north-centred power sharing the subcontinent with other independent regional kingdoms.

21. Land grants were typically recorded on copper plates rather than perishable materials. The most likely reason was that the grant-holder wanted:

- (A) A durable, lasting record of his rights to the land that would survive over generations.
- (B) A document light enough to carry on long sea voyages to Rome.
- (C) A surface on which the king could later easily erase the grant.
- (D) Coins he could melt down and spend whenever he wished.

22. Prabhavati Gupta governed as regent after her husband's death and kept strong ties between kingdoms. Her career is best taken as evidence that:

- (A) Women were never permitted any role in governance in ancient India.
- (B) Only foreign queens were ever allowed to rule in India.

- (C) She personally led the Gupta armies into every major battle.
- (D) Royal women in this period could at times wield real political power.

23. Varahamihira's Brihat Samhita is best described as which kind of work?

- (A) A praise-inscription celebrating Samudragupta's conquests.
- (B) An encyclopedic compilation covering astronomy and a wide range of subjects.
- (C) A play about love written for the Gupta court stage.
- (D) A copper-plate record of a tax-free village grant.

24. A student writes, 'Aryabhata invented the wheel of the universe by carving the Iron Pillar.' Identify the mix-up.

- (A) Aryabhata was a mathematician-astronomer who wrote the Aryabhatiya; the Iron Pillar is a metalwork marvel linked to a Gupta king, not to him.
- (B) There is no mix-up; Aryabhata both wrote on astronomy and forged the pillar.
- (C) The mix-up is only the date; Aryabhata did carve the pillar but in a later century.
- (D) Aryabhata was a poet, so he wrote the pillar's praise-verses, which is correct.

25. Why does the survival of the rust-resistant Iron Pillar tell historians something specific about Gupta-age technology?

- (A) It shows the Guptas imported all their metal ready-made from Rome.
- (B) It proves the Guptas had no knowledge of any metal except gold.
- (C) It shows that the period's metalworkers had advanced iron-making skill, producing iron that resists corrosion for centuries.
- (D) It demonstrates that ancient Indians could not yet work iron at all.

26. Faxian was a pilgrim, meaning a person who travels to holy places. Given this, what was his primary purpose in coming to India?

- (A) To serve as Samudragupta's court poet and compose his prashasti.
- (B) To command a Huna army invading from the northwest.
- (C) To visit Buddhist sacred sites and collect religious texts, observing Indian society along the way.
- (D) To rule a Gupta province as a Chinese governor.

27. Which pairing of ruler and achievement is the correct one?

- (A) Chandragupta I — the rust-resistant Delhi Iron Pillar.
- (B) Chandragupta II — the very first Gupta to take an imperial title.
- (C) Samudragupta — celebrated in the Prayaga Prashasti for his conquests.
- (D) Kumaragupta — the Chinese pilgrim who toured India.

28. The title 'Chakravartin' claimed by powerful rulers carried the idea of:

- (A) A temple priest who performed daily worship for the king.
- (B) A village headman responsible for local taxes only.

- (C) A foreign ambassador sent to negotiate trade treaties.
- (D) A universal sovereign whose authority extended over all lesser kings.

29. If the Prayaga Prashasti, gold coins, and overseas graffiti all point in the same direction about Gupta trade and power, this agreement is valuable because it:

- (A) Lets historians cross-check different kinds of evidence, making the conclusion more trustworthy.
- (B) Proves a single source is always enough on its own.
- (C) Shows that written inscriptions can now be safely ignored.
- (D) Demonstrates that the Guptas kept no records of any kind.

30. Ayurveda, meaning the 'science of life', was systematically organised in this era. To 'codify' such knowledge means to:

- (A) Destroy the old texts so the knowledge is forgotten.
- (B) Keep it a permanent secret known to one family only.
- (C) Translate every word of it into the Greek language.
- (D) Arrange and write it down in an organised, systematic form.

31. Which statement best captures why historians prize Gupta gold coins as a source despite their royal propaganda?

- (A) They are neutral records with no royal message, so they need no critical reading.
- (B) They are useless because anything a king issued must be entirely false.
- (C) They matter only as raw gold and tell historians nothing about the rulers.
- (D) They are dateable physical objects that reveal rulers, their imagery and the empire's wealth, even while their messages must be read critically.

32. Sarnath and Udayagiri are mentioned for their sculpture. These belong to which strand of Gupta achievement?

- (A) Mathematics, as centres where zero was first written.
- (B) Maritime trade hubs exporting goods to Socotra.
- (C) Royal mints producing the empire's gold coins.
- (D) Art and architecture, including carved stone images and temple sites.

33. Chandragupta I is said to have strengthened the dynasty through marriage to a Licchavi princess. The best label for this strategy is:

- (A) A purely religious rite with no bearing on politics.
- (B) A matrimonial alliance that boosted the new dynasty's prestige and power.
- (C) A method of collecting the empire's yearly land tax.
- (D) A treaty to hand the Gupta throne over to the Licchavis.

34. The Gupta age is called India's 'Classical' or 'Golden' age above all because of its:

- (A) High achievements in art, science and literature, later looked back on as a model.
- (B) Complete social equality enjoyed by every subject.

- (C) Total freedom from any warfare during the whole period.
- (D) Rejection of all earlier Indian learning and tradition.

35. A pilgrim's travel account and a king's prashasti differ as sources mainly in that:

- (A) The prashasti is unbiased while the pilgrim's account is pure fiction.
- (B) Both are written by the same court poet for the same king.
- (C) The pilgrim is an outside observer describing society he passed through, while the prashasti is composed to glorify a particular ruler.
- (D) Neither can be used because both are written documents.

36. Garuda appears as a royal emblem on Gupta symbols. Its use is best read as showing that the Guptas:

- (A) Drew on Hindu religious imagery, with Garuda as the vehicle of Vishnu, to express their authority.
- (B) Worshipped only foreign Greek gods and rejected Indian ones.
- (C) Ruled strictly as a Buddhist-only dynasty banning other faiths.
- (D) Had no interest in religion and used random animal pictures.

37. The Hunas who pressed on the later Guptas, and earlier foreign groups too, entered India through the northwest. This recurring pattern suggests the northwest was:

- (A) A region completely sealed off by impassable mountains.
- (B) India's single richest stretch of farmland.
- (C) A repeated gateway through which invaders and migrants entered the subcontinent.
- (D) The empire's main seaport for ocean trade.

38. A claim runs: 'Because Faxian praised Gupta charity, Gupta society must have been fair to all.' The flaw in this reasoning is that:

- (A) Faxian never mentioned charity, so the premise is invented.
- (B) Charity in cities does not prove fairness for all, and Faxian himself noted the exclusion of the chandalas.
- (C) Charity always guarantees complete social equality everywhere.
- (D) Faxian was a Gupta king and so cannot be trusted at all.

39. Which best explains why the Gupta state's grand titles and elaborate administration were developed?

- (A) To disguise the fact that the Guptas commanded no army at all.
- (B) To prove publicly that the Gupta rulers were foreigners.
- (C) To project the emperor's supreme authority and to organise governance across a large realm.
- (D) To make royal officials unnecessary and abolish their posts.

40. Aryabhata's calculation of an accurate value for pi is significant chiefly because it shows that Gupta-age scholars could:

- (A) Work out precise mathematical results about circles, reflecting advanced and careful computation.
- (B) Predict the exact dates of all future Huna invasions.
- (C) Replace the need for the number zero in all calculations.
- (D) Determine the price of gold coins in distant Rome.

41. Why is it inaccurate to say 'the Guptas ruled the whole subcontinent directly, just as the Mauryas had'?

- (A) The Guptas directly governed mainly the north and centre and relied on land grants and allied kings elsewhere, with other kingdoms ruling the south and northeast.
- (B) Because the Guptas in fact controlled only the single city of Pataliputra.
- (C) Because the Guptas were a loose alliance with no central ruler at all.
- (D) Because the Guptas had no territory and existed only as traders.

42. The flourishing of Kalidasa, Aryabhata and Varahamihira together at or near the Gupta court is best explained by the rulers acting as:

- (A) Patrons who supported poets, scientists and scholars.
- (B) Regents ruling temporarily on behalf of child-kings.
- (C) Foreign conquerors who suppressed all learning.
- (D) Pilgrims who travelled abroad seeking texts.

43. Assertion: Saying 'Chandragupta II built the empire that the Mauryas had lost' confuses two dynasties. Reason: Chandragupta II belonged to the Mauryas. Choose the best judgement.

- (A) Both the assertion and the reason are true and correctly explain each other.
- (B) The assertion is true but the reason is false: Chandragupta II was a Gupta, not a Maurya, which is exactly the confusion to avoid.
- (C) The assertion is false because the two dynasties are actually the same.
- (D) Both are false because Chandragupta II never existed.

44. What does the existence of detailed copper-plate land grants tell historians about Gupta administration?

- (A) That the Guptas kept no records and ruled by word of mouth only.
- (B) That all land in the empire was owned directly by foreign kings.
- (C) That the state recorded rights to land in writing, showing an organised, documented system of governance.
- (D) That the Guptas used coins instead of any written documents.

45. The Vakatakas, into whose royal family Prabhavati Gupta married, are best understood as:

- (A) A group of Chinese pilgrims visiting Gupta India.
- (B) The Central Asian invaders who destroyed the Guptas.

- (C) A school of mathematicians who taught Aryabhata.
- (D) A contemporary ruling dynasty allied to the Guptas through marriage.

46. Why is the Aryabhatiya considered a milestone of Gupta-age science?

- (A) It is a long epic poem about a Gupta king's love affairs.
- (B) It is the inscription recording Samudragupta's victories.
- (C) It is a concise Sanskrit treatise gathering important results in mathematics and astronomy from around 500 CE.
- (D) It is the architectural plan of the cave temples at Ajanta.

47. A timeline places the Mauryan empire, then the Kushanas, then the Guptas. Where do the Guptas fit relative to the Mauryas?

- (A) Immediately after the Mauryas, with no gap in between.
- (B) Centuries after the Mauryas, rising as a major north-Indian power around the 4th century CE.
- (C) Before the Mauryas, as the earliest empire of all.
- (D) At exactly the same time as the Mauryas, ruling jointly.

48. Faxian's praise of well-run rest-houses and hospitals for the needy, set beside his note on the chandalas, teaches that a good historian should:

- (A) Keep only the cheerful details and discard the uncomfortable ones.
- (B) Reject the entire account because it contains a single dark detail.
- (C) Assume the account was forged because it is not wholly positive.
- (D) Weigh the favourable and the troubling details together rather than seize on only one.

49. Why does the spread of the Indian decimal place-value system to other parts of the world matter for how we judge the Gupta age?

- (A) It shows the system was abandoned in India soon after it was invented.
- (B) It proves the Guptas conquered the lands that adopted the numerals.
- (C) It shows that ideas born in this era had a lasting global influence well beyond India's borders.
- (D) It means the numerals were only ever used for temple measurements.

50. Which best explains why the Guptas issued so many gold coins, in contrast to using only barter?

- (A) They had banned all trade and used coins only as temple offerings.
- (B) Gold coins replaced the need for any farming in the empire.
- (C) The coins were purely ornamental and never used in exchange.
- (D) A prosperous, trading economy needed reliable high-value currency, which the coins provided while also broadcasting royal claims.

51. The Pallava capital at Kanchipuram lay in the south, while the Gupta capital was at Pataliputra in the north. This contrast underlines that:

- (A) Distinct kingdoms with their own capitals coexisted in different regions of India in this era.
- (B) The Pallavas were a branch office of the Gupta administration.
- (C) Pataliputra and Kanchipuram were two names for the same city.
- (D) The Guptas had moved their capital south to Kanchipuram.

52. Kamarupa of this era is located in the Brahmaputra valley. Its survival as a separate kingdom shows that Gupta authority:

- (A) Did not extend over the whole subcontinent, leaving the northeast under its own rulers.
- (B) Reached every corner of India, including the far northeast directly.
- (C) Was based in the Brahmaputra valley rather than at Pataliputra.
- (D) Existed only as a network of sea-trading posts.

53. A textbook states the Gupta empire is dated roughly to the 4th to 6th centuries CE. Which earlier claim would conflict with this dating?

- (A) That Chandragupta I founded the empire's greatness in the early 4th century CE.
- (B) That the Hunas troubled the empire in the 6th century CE.
- (C) That the Guptas ruled in the 2nd century BCE, immediately following the Mauryas.
- (D) That Samudragupta's conquests fell within the 4th century CE.

54. Why does the phrase 'Age of Tireless Creativity' suit the Gupta period?

- (A) Because the era saw no creative work but endless warfare instead.
- (B) Because creativity was limited to a single year of the empire.
- (C) Because the era produced sustained outpourings of literature, science, mathematics and art.
- (D) Because the phrase refers only to the minting of coins.

55. Suppose a coin shows a Gupta king as an archer and an inscription calls him 'Maharajadhiraja'. Reading these together, the safest conclusion is that the ruler wished to appear:

- (A) A mighty warrior and supreme overlord, projecting both martial strength and paramount status.
- (B) A humble servant of the common villagers with no claim to power.
- (C) A pilgrim who had given up the throne to travel to holy places.
- (D) A foreign trader visiting India to buy gold.

56. Which conclusion about the spread of Hinduism and Buddhist art in the Gupta era is best supported by the chapter's evidence?

- (A) Only Greek religious art was made anywhere in the empire.
- (B) Both Hindu imagery, such as Garuda and temple sculpture, and Buddhist art, such as Ajanta paintings, were produced and patronised in the period.
- (C) All religious art was banned by the Gupta rulers.
- (D) Art was confined entirely to mathematical diagrams.

57. A student argues that 'science and art can flourish even when an empire is not perfectly fair.' The strongest evidence from the Gupta age for this claim is that:

- (A) Every Gupta subject was treated equally and shared the wealth.
- (B) Dazzling work by Aryabhata and Kalidasa coexisted with the harsh exclusion of the chandalas.
- (C) The Guptas produced no science or art whatsoever.
- (D) The Guptas governed with no titles and no administration.

58. Why is Pataliputra (present-day Patna) significant in the study of both the Mauryan and Gupta empires?

- (A) It served as a major capital for both dynasties, though they ruled centuries apart.
- (B) It proves the two dynasties were really one and the same.
- (C) It was the Pallava capital that both empires fought over.
- (D) It was a southern port that neither dynasty ever controlled.

59. The most accurate summary of the Gupta legacy is that the period:

- (A) Left lasting contributions in mathematics, science, literature and art that influenced India and the world, while its society remained unequal.
- (B) Left nothing of lasting value and is remembered only for its decline.
- (C) Achieved perfect social equality but produced no notable culture.
- (D) Was entirely the work of Chandragupta Maurya and the Mauryan state.

60. Why is it reasonable to treat the later Gupta period as a time of strain rather than uninterrupted glory?

- (A) The Guptas suddenly forgot all their mathematics and could no longer govern.
- (B) A Roman army permanently occupied Pataliputra and ruled in their place.
- (C) The Pallavas of the south absorbed the entire Gupta heartland in a single year.
- (D) Mounting Huna invasions and the loss of revenue from repeated land grants steadily weakened the empire in its final century.

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 7: The Gupta Era — Paper 3

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	B	11	B	21	A	31	D	41	A	51	A
2	B	12	D	22	D	32	D	42	A	52	A
3	A	13	B	23	B	33	B	43	B	53	C
4	B	14	D	24	A	34	A	44	C	54	C
5	C	15	D	25	C	35	C	45	D	55	A
6	C	16	B	26	C	36	A	46	C	56	B
7	A	17	B	27	C	37	C	47	B	57	B
8	D	18	C	28	D	38	B	48	D	58	A
9	D	19	C	29	A	39	C	49	C	59	A
10	B	20	D	30	D	40	A	50	D	60	D

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (B) The imperial Gupta line runs Chandragupta I, then his son Samudragupta, then Chandragupta II. The list misplaces Chandragupta I, who actually founded the empire's greatness and ruled earliest; he is the father of Samudragupta. Putting Chandragupta II first reverses the whole descent, and the three are distinct individuals (a grandfather, son and grandson), not one person renamed over time. So only moving Chandragupta I to the front fixes it.

2. (B) The Prayaga Prashasti, composed by the court poet Harishena, celebrates the wide conquests of Samudragupta, the warrior king. Chandragupta II reigned after him and is remembered above all as a patron of arts and sciences and for defeating the Shakas, not as the subject of that inscription. The inscription names one ruler, not both, and it belongs to the Gupta age, not to the much earlier Maurya Chandragupta. Hence crediting it to Chandragupta II misreads who the eulogy is about.

3. (A) Chandragupta Maurya belonged to the Mauryan empire roughly seven centuries before the Guptas; the Iron Pillar and its 'Chandra' inscription fit the Gupta period and Chandragupta II. The name 'Chandragupta' itself contains 'Chandra', so that element is shared, not unique. The Mauryas certainly worked iron and many metals, so the gold claim is false. And Vikramaditya is a Gupta title, not a shared one, so the deciding factor is the gap of centuries between the two dynasties.

4. (B) Iron normally rusts readily, so the blanket claim is false. The Delhi pillar endures because the ancient smiths used phosphorus-rich iron that develops a thin passive film, protecting the metal from oxygen and water for over a thousand years. The pillar is genuinely iron, not bronze, and its protection is built into the metal's chemistry, not a yearly coat of paint. So the marvel is the metallurgy, not any idea that iron cannot corrode.

5. (C) Faxian, a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim, travelled through India during the Gupta age and saw mostly the prosperous towns and pious institutions; his own account also reveals the harsh exclusion of the chandalas, showing prosperity was uneven. He was a genuine traveller writing of what he witnessed, not a copyist or a later author, and he was an outside pilgrim, not a paid court flatterer. The lesson is that one eyewitness shows a partial view and should be checked against other evidence such as coins and inscriptions.

6. (C) A tax-free grant means that land no longer feeds revenue into the royal treasury, and the grant-holder gains rights over the local people and resources; repeated over generations this erodes both income and central control. It cannot raise revenue, since the whole point is exemption from tax. It does not bear on raising armies or on long-distance maritime trade, which continued independently. So the long-run effect is a quiet weakening of the king's direct grip.

7. (A) The Guptas held the north and centre under direct rule but elsewhere leaned on land grants and allied or tributary kings, a looser arrangement than the Mauryan model of close direct control everywhere. There was no yearly elected national assembly choosing the king, no use of Roman officials, and the emperor remained very much the supreme authority, projecting it through grand titles. Hence the distinguishing feature is the reliance on grants and subordinate rulers.

8. (D) Defeating the Shakas in the west gave the Guptas the prosperous western territories and access to coastal trade toward the Arabian Sea, strengthening the empire economically. The Guptas did not conquer China, and the Mauryas had fallen centuries before the Shakas, so neither is relevant. Zero was a mathematical achievement of Indian scholars such as Aryabhata, not a treasure seized in war. The real reward was strategic and commercial reach to the west.

9. (D) Aryabhata's striking idea was that the daily rising and setting of stars is explained by the Earth rotating on its axis, an explanation that puts the motion in the observer rather than in the whole sky. This is not a claim that the Earth is flat, nor a statement about the

Sun's yearly path, nor a claim that the stars physically race across the country. The boldness lay in attributing the apparent motion of the heavens to the Earth's spin.

10. (B) Zero as a place-holder within a decimal place-value system lets any quantity be written compactly and calculated efficiently, and the method eventually travelled across the world to become standard arithmetic. It did not replace all other numerals; rather it works with them. It was a general tool for all calculation, not a one-off for architecture, and it was preserved and transmitted, not forgotten. Its lasting, worldwide usefulness is what makes it so significant.

11. (B) The prashasti is a real and useful source for Samudragupta, and it was indeed written by his court poet Harishena, so both statements are true. But because the author worked for the king, the eulogy is likely to exaggerate, so its claims should be cross-checked rather than accepted as neutral fact. It is not worthless, and Harishena was the king's poet, not a rival. The careful position is to use it while allowing for bias.

12. (D) Scholars travelling great distances to study at Nalanda show that it was a renowned centre of higher learning whose reputation reached far beyond India. This does not mean local students were excluded or that study was banned at home; quite the opposite, learning was thriving. Nalanda was an educational institution, not a fortress. Its pull on distant scholars reflects the era's intellectual prestige.

13. (B) Coins were a public, widely circulating medium, so the chosen images broadcast the king's might, varied talents and rightful authority to all who handled them. They were money carrying a political message, not mere ornaments, and they recorded royal claims rather than weather. Showing a king as a musician displayed cultivation alongside martial scenes; it did not signal the absence of an army. The purpose was projecting legitimacy and prestige.

14. (D) Ajanta's fame rests on its painted cave walls, largely depicting Buddhist subjects, which display the era's mastery of colour and composition. They are paintings, not coins, not astronomical charts, and not legal copper-plate grants. So they belong squarely to the chapter's theme of artistic achievement.

15. (D) A 'king of kings' title asserts paramount status above other rulers, fitting an empire that held subordinate and allied kings beneath the emperor. A plain 'raja' would claim only a single kingship. The grand title is not the mark of a headman, nor of a king who surrendered power, nor of a priest. It is precisely a statement of overlordship.

16. (B) The continued performance of Kalidasa's works across many centuries shows that the literature of the Gupta court achieved an enduring quality that outlasted the political empire. This longevity argues for the antiquity and excellence of the works, not that they are modern forgeries, and it shows the era prized literature as well as science. Far from nothing surviving, these very texts are the survivors. The point is the lasting legacy.

17. (B) Traders leaving their marks on a distant island shows the long reach of Indian seaborne commerce, not political conquest. There is no evidence the Guptas governed Socotra; their capital was Pataliputra, far inland; and the graffiti points to Indians travelling out, not islanders invading India. So the inference is about trade and travel, not empire.

18. (C) Brilliant achievements in art and science coexisted with deep social inequality, including the marginalisation of the chandalas, so 'golden' describes culture, not social fairness. There was neither universal equality nor an absence of conflict, and India was in fact well connected by trade. The corrective is to remember the splendour did not reach everyone.

19. (C) The Hunas, coming from Central Asia through the northwest, wore down the later Guptas and hastened the empire's break-up. The Pallavas were a southern kingdom that did not conquer the north, no Roman army invaded India, and Chandragupta Maurya belonged to a far earlier dynasty, so his death is irrelevant here. The proximate cause was the Huna onslaught.

20. (D) The simultaneous existence of strong southern and north-eastern kingdoms shows the Guptas did not rule all of India; they dominated the north and centre while other powers held their own regions. India was not a single Gupta realm, was not a Chinese province, and the Pallavas and Kamarupa were full kingdoms, not Gupta villages. The picture is one of a major empire alongside regional states.

21. (A) A tax-free or tenure grant was meant to last, so it was engraved on copper, a material that endures and is hard to tamper with, preserving the claim across generations. The point was permanence, not portability for travel, and copper was chosen precisely because it could not be easily altered or erased. A copper plate is a record, not spendable coinage. Durability of the legal right is the answer.

22. (D) A Gupta princess ruling as regent and managing inter-kingdom relations shows that elite women could exercise genuine authority. This contradicts the idea that women were wholly barred from governance, and Prabhavati was an Indian princess, not a foreigner. The sources credit her with administration and diplomacy, not with leading armies in battle. Her example illustrates women's occasional real political power.

23. (B) The Brihat Samhita is a broad, encyclopedic text associated with the scholar Varahamihira, ranging over astronomy and many fields of knowledge. It is not a royal eulogy like the Prayaga Prashasti, not a dramatic play like Kalidasa's, and not a legal land-grant document. So it belongs to the era's scientific and scholarly output.

24. (A) Aryabhata's domain was mathematics and astronomy, captured in his treatise the Aryabhatiya; he had nothing to do with forging the Delhi Iron Pillar, which is a feat of metallurgy connected to a Gupta ruler. So the sentence wrongly fuses a scholar with a

metalwork monument. He was not an ironsmith at any date, and he was a scientist, not the pillar's poet. The two belong to entirely different achievements of the age.

25. (C) An iron column that has resisted rust for over a millennium is direct physical proof of sophisticated indigenous iron technology in the Gupta age. It does not imply imported Roman metal, and it plainly contradicts any notion that Indians worked only gold or could not work iron. The pillar is evidence of high local metallurgical skill.

26. (C) As a Buddhist pilgrim, Faxian came chiefly to see holy sites and gather scriptures, and his travel writings incidentally record what he saw of Gupta society. He was not a Gupta court poet (that was Harishena), not a military commander, and not an administrator of any province. His religious journey is what places his account in the chapter.

27. (C) The Prayaga Prashasti praises Samudragupta, so that pairing is correct. The Iron Pillar's 'Chandra' is linked to Chandragupta II, not Chandragupta I; the first to raise the Guptas to imperial status was Chandragupta I, not Chandragupta II; and the touring pilgrim was Faxian, a Chinese Buddhist, not the king Kumaragupta. Only the Samudragupta pairing holds.

28. (D) Chakravartin expresses the ideal of a paramount, world-encompassing ruler standing above all other kings, an aspiration suited to imperial claims. It is not a priestly, local, or diplomatic role. The term is about supreme overlordship.

29. (A) When independent sources of different types converge, each helps confirm the others, so the overall picture becomes more reliable. This is the opposite of trusting one source alone, and it increases rather than removes the value of inscriptions. It also clearly shows the Guptas did keep abundant records. Corroboration across evidence is the key benefit.

30. (D) Codifying means setting knowledge out in an ordered, written, systematic way so it can be taught and preserved. It is not destruction, not secrecy, and not specifically translation into Greek. The medical learning of the age was thus given lasting written form.

31. (D) Coins survive as concrete, often dateable artefacts that name rulers and display their claims and the realm's prosperity, so they are rich evidence even though the images are deliberate self-promotion to be weighed carefully. They are not message-free, nor are they worthless simply because a king made them, and they carry far more meaning than their metal value. The balanced view is to use them critically.

32. (D) Sarnath and Udayagiri are noted for sculpture and religious architecture, marking them as achievements in art. They are not mathematical centres, not seaports, and not mints. Their carved images place them within the era's artistic flowering.

33. (B) Marrying into the established Licchavi line lent the rising Guptas legitimacy and allies, a classic political marriage. It was not a tax-collecting device, nor merely a religious ceremony, and it raised the Guptas rather than surrendering their throne. So it is best described as a matrimonial alliance for power.

34. (A) The label honours the period's outstanding cultural and scientific accomplishments, which later generations admired. It does not claim universal equality, nor an absence of war, nor a break with past learning; in fact Gupta scholars built on earlier knowledge. The brilliance of its arts and sciences earns the title.

35. (C) A pilgrim such as Faxian writes as an outsider recording what he encounters, whereas a prashasti like Harishena's is purpose-built praise of one king and thus shaped by the wish to flatter. The prashasti is therefore the more partial of the two, not the neutral one, and the two were produced by very different authors for very different reasons. Both are usable written sources when read with their purposes in mind.

36. (A) Garuda, the mount of Vishnu, links Gupta kingship to Hindu devotional imagery, lending the rulers divine sanction. The Guptas did not adopt Greek gods, were not an exclusively Buddhist dynasty, and chose Garuda deliberately for its religious meaning, not at random. The emblem ties royal power to Hindu tradition.

37. (C) That successive outside groups arrived by the northwest marks it as a recurring overland entry point into India. It was clearly not sealed off, since people kept coming through it, and the description concerns movement of peoples, not farmland fertility or maritime ports. The northwest functioned as a historic gateway.

38. (B) Visible urban charity does not establish equality across the whole society, and Faxian's own report records the harsh exclusion of the chandalas, undercutting the conclusion. He did mention charity, so the premise stands, and charity does not by itself guarantee equality. Faxian was a pilgrim, not a king. The reasoning over-generalises from one prosperous slice of society.

39. (C) Imposing titles and a structured administration both advertised the emperor's paramount status and provided the machinery to run a wide empire. They did not mask a missing army, did not declare the Guptas foreign, and certainly did not remove the need for officials, who staffed that very administration. The aim was authority and organisation.

40. (A) Arriving at a close value of pi demonstrates a sophisticated grasp of geometry and computation among Gupta mathematicians. It is unrelated to forecasting invasions or to coin prices in Rome, and it complements rather than replaces the use of zero. The achievement signals genuine mathematical advancement.

41. (A) Gupta direct rule centred on the north and centre, while the rest was managed through grants and subordinate or allied kings, and regions like the south (Pallavas) and northeast (Kamarupa) lay outside Gupta control. They governed far more than one city,

did have a strong central emperor, and held real territory, so the other claims are false. The empire was substantial but not subcontinent-wide direct rule.

42. (A) A cluster of leading writers and scientists thriving under royal favour points to active patronage, kings funding and encouraging talent. The rulers were full sovereigns, not regents, and they fostered rather than suppressed learning, and they were kings at home, not travelling pilgrims. Patronage explains the concentration of genius.

43. (B) The statement does muddle two dynasties, so the assertion is sound, but the reason errs by calling Chandragupta II a Maurya when he was a Gupta ruler centuries after the Mauryas. The dynasties are distinct, not identical, and Chandragupta II was a real historical king. Correctly, he was a Gupta, which is the very distinction students must keep straight.

44. (C) Engraved land grants prove the administration kept formal written records of who held which land and on what terms, evidence of an organised bureaucracy. This contradicts the idea of an unrecorded oral system, does not show foreign ownership, and shows that documents existed alongside coins rather than being replaced by them. The grants reveal a documented governing order.

45. (D) The Vakatakas were a separate ruling house linked to the Guptas by Prabhavati Gupta's marriage, illustrating how marriage built alliances between dynasties. They were not pilgrims, not the Huna invaders, and not a school of scholars. They were a contemporary allied dynasty.

46. (C) The Aryabhatiya compactly sets out major mathematical and astronomical findings of its time, marking a high point of scientific writing. It is not a poem, not the Prayaga Prashasti, and not an architectural drawing. Its scientific content is what makes it a landmark.

47. (B) The Guptas emerged long after the Mauryan empire, with the Kushana period falling in between, so a substantial gap separates the two. They did not follow the Mauryas at once, did not precede them, and did not rule alongside them. Recognising this gap is what prevents conflating the two Chandraguptas.

48. (D) A balanced reading uses both the positive observations and the disturbing ones to build a fuller, fairer picture. Cherry-picking the pleasant parts distorts the past, while discarding the whole source over one detail wastes good evidence, and the presence of mixed reporting actually argues for authenticity, not forgery. Holding the contrasting details together is the historian's task.

49. (C) That the place-value system travelled widely and became the basis of arithmetic across the world testifies to the deep, lasting impact of Gupta-age learning. The system was not abandoned at home, its spread came through transmission of knowledge rather than

conquest, and it served all kinds of calculation, not just architecture. Its global reach underscores the era's significance.

50. (D) A flourishing economy with long-distance trade required dependable money, so the abundant gold coinage served real commerce while also carrying the ruler's image and titles. Trade was thriving, not banned; coins did not displace farming, the economy's base; and they functioned as money, not mere ornaments. Economic need plus royal messaging explains the coinage.

51. (A) Two separate capitals in two regions show that independent kingdoms governed different parts of India simultaneously. The Pallavas were not a Gupta sub-office, the two cities were genuinely different places, and the Guptas kept their capital at Pataliputra in the north. The contrast highlights regional political diversity.

52. (A) An independent Kamarupa in the northeast demonstrates that Gupta direct rule had limits and did not cover the entire subcontinent. Gupta power did not reach every corner, their base was Pataliputra rather than the Brahmaputra valley, and they were a land empire, not merely trading posts. Kamarupa marks the edge of Gupta reach.

53. (C) Placing the Guptas in the 2nd century BCE, right after the Mauryas, clashes with the accepted 4th-to-6th-century CE dating and reflects the classic confusion with the Mauryan age. The other statements all sit comfortably inside the correct span: Chandragupta I early, Samudragupta mid-period, and the Huna pressure near the end. Only the BCE claim is inconsistent.

54. (C) The label fits because the period saw rich and continuing achievements across literature, mathematics, astronomy and art. It was not an age devoid of creativity, the flourishing spanned generations rather than one year, and it covered far more than coinage. The breadth and persistence of creative work justify the phrase.

55. (A) The archer image signals martial prowess and the 'king of kings' title signals supremacy, so together they present a powerful, paramount ruler. They do not depict humility, renunciation of the throne, or a foreign merchant. The combined message is one of warlike strength and overlordship.

56. (B) The era's surviving works include Hindu royal emblems and temple sculpture as well as Buddhist cave paintings at Ajanta, showing patronage across traditions. There is no sign of an empire of only Greek art, no ban on religious art, and art was certainly not limited to mathematical diagrams. Both Hindu and Buddhist artistic strands flourished.

57. (B) The point is best proved by setting the era's brilliant achievements beside its real social injustice, such as the treatment of the chandalas, which is exactly what the Gupta record shows. Claiming universal equality would undercut the argument, denying any science or art is plainly false, and the Guptas in fact had elaborate titles and administration. Greatness alongside unfairness is the supporting evidence.

58. (A) Pataliputra was an important capital for the Mauryas and again for the Guptas, even though the two empires were separated by centuries; sharing a capital does not make them the same dynasty. It was not the Pallava capital (that was Kanchipuram), and it was an inland northern city, not a southern port. The shared capital links the two ages geographically while their identities remain distinct.

59. (A) The Gupta age is remembered for enduring achievements in mathematics, astronomy, literature and art that shaped later India and beyond, even as social inequalities persisted. It did leave a rich legacy rather than nothing, its fame rests on culture rather than on equality it never achieved, and it belonged to the Gupta dynasty, not to Chandragupta Maurya's Mauryan state. Cultural brilliance amid social inequality is the fair summary.

60. (D) Toward its end the Gupta empire faced repeated Huna pressure from the northwest, while generations of tax-free land grants had drained royal revenue and dispersed authority, so the late period was one of decline. The empire did not lose its accumulated knowledge, no Roman army occupied the capital, and the southern Pallavas did not swallow the Gupta heartland. The strain came from invasions and the long-term cost of granting away revenue.